2022. "International students fund American universities and enrich their intellectual climate," says Timothy Gibson, president of the Virginia Conference of the American Association of University Professors. "If the administration continues to view them through a xenophobic lens, the US risks losing its standing as a global leader in science and research."

The Trump administration has also put a freeze on several federal grants and funding programmes that facilitate international scholarships and student exchanges, the Fulbright and Gilman scholarship programmes among them. Another area of concern is the potential restrictions on the Optional Practical Training (OPT) programme, which currently allows international STEM graduates to work in the US for up to three years. If the administration decides to limit or dismantle OPT, it would drastically reduce the opportunities for foreign graduates to gain practical work experience, jeopardising their career prospects and deterring future enrolment.

HIGH ANXIETY

Mary Gogoi, head of admissions at Delhi-based education counselling firm eduVelocity Global, says, "All these developments have bred anxiety in international students, as well as among American universities that rely on this cohort for cultural diversity and financial sustainability." Nothing illustrates this better than the case of a 24-year-old girl student, who does not wish to be named. Admitted into a US university for a master's in computer science with specialisation in AI, her visa application was rejected for no clear reason, forcing her to reapply. Keen on only the US as she finds it the best for research and innovation, she is thinking of deferring her course by a year if visas are not scheduled soon.

The Trump administration's latest directive—to vet social media accounts before sanctioning a student visa—is also adding to the consternation. Of course, as Rohin Kapoor, partner, education and skilling at global consultancy firm BDO India, points out, social media vetting is not unique to the US; Australia and Canada, too, screen the social media posts of applicants. The current US policy also builds on social media checks introduced in 2019. Now, however, the State Department has said it will use "all available information" to identify "antisemitic activity", "pro-jihadist" views or "anti-American" sentiments. Charles H. Kuck, founding partner of Atlanta-based law firm Kuck Baxter, which specialises in immigration laws, explains what this means. "Social media vetting has existed for years," he says. "But now artificial intelligence reviews all postings. This violates the core American values of free speech and personal liberty; yet, the administration shows little concern for those principles when it comes to foreigners." Poorvi Chothani, managing partner at immigration



AFP

THE TRUMP CLAMPDOWN

The Trump administration has introduced barriers for foreign students seeking education in the US. The policies have a range of targets, from visa processes to the stability of top institutions. Here are the main features of the clampdown looming before Indian students:

SUSPENSION OF STUDENT VISA INTERVIEWS

The Trump administration has halted the scheduling of new student visa (F-1) appointments at US embassies, including in India, though previously scheduled interviews are proceeding. The delays have caused uncertainty for Indians about to commence studies in the US

ENHANCED SOCIAL MEDIA VETTING

There are directives for an expansion of social media scrutiny for student visa applicants, ostensibly to "enhance national security". Anything "radical/anti-American" would reduce chances for a visa, raising concerns about privacy

VISA REVOCATIONS BASED ON POLITICAL ACTIVITY

The Trump administration has revoked 300+ student visas for foreign students, targeting those involved in "pro-Palestinian activism". This has already led to deportation in some cases. Further, on June 4, Trump suspended for six months the entry of foreign students in Harvard University due to "security risks"